Appendix A: Joining Conference

Download as PDF: Joining Conference Template (PDF)

Overview

Every Scout who joins Troop 500G brings their own unique strengths, interests, and needs — and this conference is our chance to learn about yours. By taking a little time to talk before your Scout's first campout, we can make sure our leaders are prepared to support them from day one. This form is a guide for that conversation, not an evaluation — there are no wrong answers, and you are always welcome to leave any question blank. Everything shared here stays confidential within our leadership team and is used only to help your Scout thrive.

A Conversation Guide

The Lake Erie Council Accessibility and Inclusion Committee encourages Units to hold joining conferences with every incoming Scout. These meetings are between leaders (often Scoutmasters, Assistant Scoutmasters, and New Member Coordinators), parents, and Scouts. Joining meetings encourage inclusive, strengths-based conversations to better understand and support each Scout's unique needs. The conference should take place within the first month after a Scout joins, and is designed to build partnerships with families rather than evaluate suitability.

Inclusive

Joining conferences are held for every Scout, recognizing that all Scouts have unique needs and strengths. Some may require additional support, but every Scout benefits from understanding and partnership.

Confidentiality & Privacy

The goal of joining conferences is to provide leaders enough information to support Scouts during camping and troop activities. While confidentiality is important, we ask that parents and guardians share enough information with our trained leaders to help their Scout succeed. Required Annual Health and Medical Forms store private medical information and are not authorized for digital storage. All joining conference information is stored in Troop 500G Google Drive, with access limited to adult troop leaders who need it to provide support to your Scout. If you have privacy concerns, please let us know. You may leave any fields blank if you prefer not to share certain information. All details discussed are kept confidential unless explicit permission is given to share with other leaders.

You're part of the team

Leaders, parents, and Scouts work together as a team, and the goal is a supportive partnership where every Scout can thrive. Open communication is essential — if something is worrying you, please say so. If something is unclear, just ask. We would rather hear about a concern early than have a Scout struggle in silence.

Strengths-Based

Every Scout brings their own unique strengths, talents, and interests. The joining conference focuses on identifying and building upon these strengths, helping Scouts feel confident and valued in the troop. That said, building on strengths is most effective when leaders also understand where a Scout might struggle — knowing potential challenges helps us provide the right support before small difficulties become bigger ones.

No Diagnosis Required

The conversation is about what helps the Scout succeed — not about medical diagnoses or labels. Families are encouraged to share strategies, preferences, and needs, regardless of whether there is a formal diagnosis.

Conducted Post-Joining

The joining conference is held after the Scout has joined the troop. It is not an evaluation or selection process, but a way to welcome the Scout and ensure they have the support they need from the start.

An Ongoing Conversation

The joining conference is just the beginning of a supportive relationship. Scouts, parents, and leaders all grow and change, and so do their needs. Any leader, Scout, or parent may request another conference at any time to revisit goals, address new challenges, or update support strategies. We especially encourage a follow-up conference with leaders and families before Scouts attend summer camp, to ensure everyone is prepared and supported for new experiences.

Pre-Meeting Checklist

This section is to be completed by troop leadership prior to the Joining Conference.

- ☐ Scout has joined the Troop *(beascout.scouting.org)*
- ☐ Private, confidential meeting space arranged *(out of earshot of others)*
- ☐ At least one disability-awareness trained leader present if possible
- ☐ Family understands this is about understanding their Scout, not evaluation
- ☐ Troop 500G Handbook *(Printed Hardcopy)*
- ☐ Below form has been sent to family for review

Scout Contact Information

Scout Name: _____ Age: _____

Gender: _____ Preferred Pronouns:_____

Birthday: _____ Grade: _____

School: _____

Phone: _____ Scout's Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Siblings: _____

Sibling Scouting involvement: _____

Emergency Contact

Who should we contact if parent(s)/guardian(s) are unavailable?

Name: _____ Relationship: _____

Phone: _____

Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record A & B *(C before summer camp)*
- ☐ IEP / 504 *(As Needed)*
- ☐ Social Media Waiver
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar

Parent / Guardian 1 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

Skills, Interests or Resources

What do you know, or are good at that you want to share? _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Parent / Guardian 2 Contact Information

Name: _____

Relationship to Scout: _____

Phone: _____ Secondary Phone: _____

Email: _____

Address: _____

Scouting.org Member ID: _____

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

Onboarding Checklist

- ☐ Reviewed Safe Scouting Pamphlet with Scout
- ☐ Youth Protection Training Complete
- ☐ Access to GroupMe
- ☐ Access to Troop 500 Google Calendar
- ☐ Annual Health and Medical Record *As Needed*

How would you like to help?

- ☐ I would like to focus on my Scout for now!
- ☐ I can help with small side-tasks and events!
- ☐ Scouter Reserve, able to attend some campouts (Registration Required)
- ☐ Committee member (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Assistant Scoutmaster, Planning Campouts/Events (Registration / Training Required)
- ☐ Merit badge counselor (Registration / Training Required)

Skills, Interests or Resources

What do you know, or are good at that you want to share? _____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

About Your Scout

Scouting Experience

Previous Scouting Experience: _____

Why did your Scout want to join our troop? _____

_____

Does your Scout like to camp? _____

Do you consider your Scout a swimmer? _____

What is your Scout's goal in Scouting? _____

_____

Strengths & Interests

What are your Scout's unique strengths? _____

_____

What does your Scout enjoy most? What are they passionate about? _____

_____

What makes them feel successful and confident? _____

_____

Hobbies: _____

_____

Allergies / Dietary Considerations

Allergies: _____

_____

Dietary restrictions: _____

_____

Is your Scout a picky eater? What foods will they eat, and what do they refuse or strongly dislike?

_____

_____

Medical, Physical, & Sensory Considerations

Any physical limitations or accommodations needed? _____

_____

Any Medical conditions we should be aware of? (Details in AHMR) _____

_____

_____

Can your Scout take pills? _____

Is your Scout prepared for her period? _____

Bedtime and sleep routines *(important for overnight and camping trips)*:

- Regular bedtime: _____
- Bedtime routine or needs: _____
- Sleep concerns *(sleepwalking, nightmares, sleep aids, etc.)*: _____

Sensory sensitivities? (loud noises, bright lights, textures, crowds, etc.) _____

_____

What happens if your Scout misses meds? _____

_____

Learning & Communication Style

How does your Scout learn best? (visual, hands-on, verbal instructions, etc.) _____

_____

Are there any concerns with reading, writing, or comprehension? _____

_____

What strategies work well at home or school to help them learn? _____

_____

Social & Emotional Needs

How does your Scout handle new situations or changes to routine? _____

_____

What helps them be successful in small or large group settings? _____

_____

Does anything trigger anxiety, overwhelm, or emotional struggles? _____

_____

What are the warning signs when they're becoming overwhelmed? _____

_____

What strategies help when they're struggling? How can we help them succeed? _____

_____

Previous Experiences & Concerns

What accommodations or adaptations are made at home and school? _____

_____

What concerns do you have about your Scout's participation in Scouting? _____

_____

Any previous challenges with group activities or programs? _____

_____

Family Considerations

This information is kept strictly confidential and used only to ensure your Scout's safety and success.

Any family needs, situations, or custody arrangements we should be aware of?

(e.g., who may pick up the Scout, communication preferences between households, court orders, etc.)

_____

_____

_____

_____

Who is authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

Anyone who is NOT authorized to pick up the Scout? _____

Support Strategies & Action Planning

What Works for Your Scout?

Strategies that help them succeed: _____

_____

What should we make sure to do for your Scout? _____

_____

What should we avoid doing or be careful about? _____

_____

When they're struggling, how do you help them? How can we help? _____

_____

What else should we know?

What else should we know or talk about? _____

Conference Summary

To be filled out by Troop Leadership during the Joining Conference.

Main Concerns

- _____
- _____
- _____
- _____

Scout's key strengths to build upon: _____

_____

Primary support strategies identified: _____

_____

Accommodations/adaptations to implement: _____

_____